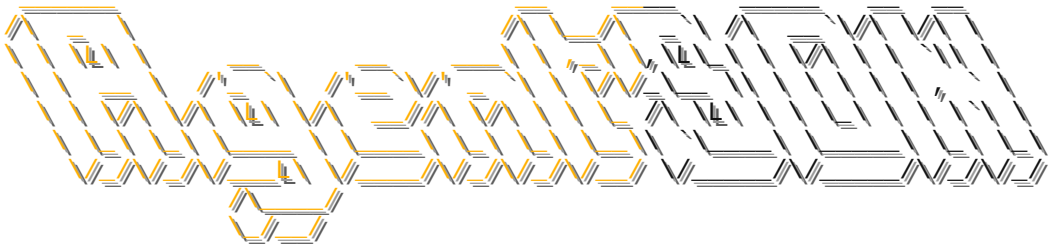
AgentSON

The Wordmark Handbook

Attempts, lineage, colour and the shipped mark



The universal provenance format for agent sessions.

Compiled 21 October 2026 • shipped face: **larry3d** • brand amber `#ffb000`, ANSI index 214

1. Why this handbook exists

The AgentSON command line had no mark. It had a boxed heading and a table of contents, and that was the whole of its visual identity. Three separate taglines had accumulated in one file, each slightly different from the others. There was no version string at all: `--version` was rejected by the argument parser, and the packaging metadata still declared a version two releases behind the newest tag.

This handbook records what was drawn, what was measured, what was rejected and why, so that the choice of mark is auditable rather than a matter of taste asserted once and forgotten. Where a decision rests on a number, the number was computed, and the method is stated. Where a decision rests on judgement, it is labelled as judgement.

> **What was actually decided**
>
> One face was drawn and shipped: **larry3d**, split by fixed column so that *Agent* renders in brand amber and *SON* in bold amber. Eight faces were surveyed and measured. One colour decision was forced by measurement: the brand amber cannot be used as ink on paper.

Two failure modes deserve to be recorded here rather than quietly corrected, because they are the interesting part. The first is that a missing comma turned seven art rows into one four hundred and thirteen character string. The second is that a test suite of one hundred and ninety two tests passed throughout, with the help system in a state that would crash the CLI on first use.

2. Lineage: how a character becomes a banner

Every large letter in this document is an illusion maintained by three separate inventions stacked on top of each other. Knowing which layer does what is what lets you change a face, recolour it, or move it to a page without breaking it.

2.1 The first constraint: ninety-five glyphs

ASCII was standardised in 1963 and gave the terminal one hundred and twenty eight code points, of which ninety five are printable. A banner built in a terminal can therefore only be assembled from those ninety five shapes. That is a hard ceiling, and it is why early computer lettering looks the way it does: heavy, blocky, and assembled from whatever dense character was available.

This constraint is not merely historical. It is the reason the `banner` face in the survey is built entirely from the hash character. A hash survives every code page, every font substitution and every terminal that can render ASCII at all. Faces that reach outside that set inherit whatever can go wrong outside it.

- **banner** uses the hash character — pure ASCII, no dependency beyond a code page that contains ASCII.
- **larry3d**, the shipped face, uses the backslash, underscore, pipe, slash, space and grave accent — also pure ASCII, but the backslash is a live escape character in several languages, which is a property of the host language rather than of the art.
- Faces built from Unicode block elements add roughly two hundred glyphs of drawing material, and lose every terminal that cannot encode them.

2.2 FIGlet and the fixed grid

FIGlet appeared in 1991 and turned the craft into a solved problem. A FIGlet font is a file of glyph grids: every character is stored as the same number of rows, and rendering a word means laying those grids side by side. This machine has five hundred and seventy one such fonts installed; eight were surveyed for this mark.

A glyph for the digit two, drawn as a five row grid, looks conceptually like this:

```
  ___
 / _ \
| | | |
| |_| |
 \___/
```

Five rows is the usual minimum that still reads as a letter. The surveyed faces range from four rows (`mini`) to nine (`larry3d`), and row count is the single strongest predictor of how much vertical room a mark consumes in a terminal that is already showing content.

2.3 The two mechanics that make it fit

Two details decide whether a rendered word looks correct or shambolic, and both are invisible in the output.

- **The hardblank.** A FIGlet font reserves one character as a placeholder for the space inside a glyph. It is substituted for a real space at render time. If the font's hardblank collides with a character the art actually uses, the substitution destroys the glyph. Faces built from backslashes are the case to watch.
- **Smushing.** Placing grids side by side leaves gaps. FIGlet can simply pad them, or it can fuse adjacent characters where their edges are compatible. Smushing is what makes a face look tight; it is also what makes a face width unpredictable, which is why every face in this survey was measured after rendering rather than reasoned about from the font definition.

> **Why the split is a column and not a string**
>
> Because rows are shared. In the shipped mark, the *Agent* half and the *SON* half occupy the same rows, and two of the nine rows contain ink from only one of them. Searching the rendered text for the letter S would find several candidates and no way to choose between them. A fixed column — forty, measured from rendering *Agent* alone — is the only deterministic boundary.

2.4 From glyph grid to colour

Once the grid exists, colour is a separate concern and is carried out of band. A terminal receives an escape sequence that changes the state of subsequent characters; the characters themselves are unchanged. The sequences this mark emits are the select-graphic-rendition family: one for the foreground in the two hundred and fifty six colour cube, and one for bold.

```
Agent   \x1b[38;5;214m   foreground 214  (amber #ffb000)
SON     \x1b[1m\x1b[38;5;214m   bold, same foreground
reset   \x1b[0m
```

The library that renders this help system models colour as a sequence of styled spans over a single text object, and converts them to escapes at output time. That indirection is what allows the same wordmark to be emitted to a terminal and drawn to a page without being rewritten, and it is the mechanism this handbook inspected to prove the two halves were styled separately.

2.5 What changes when it becomes a page

Moving the mark onto paper removes three things at once, and each removal forces a decision that the terminal never raised.

- **State does not persist.** A terminal colour is sticky between characters. A page has no state; every element is painted explicitly. The mark is therefore drawn twice per row, once per ink, at an absolutely computed position.
- **Colour becomes ink.** A bright amber that reads comfortably on a black ground has no useful lightness contrast against white paper. Section six measures this and the result decides the print treatment.
- **Monospace becomes a real font.** Courier has a fixed advance width of six tenths of an em, which preserves the grid exactly. A proportional face would not, and would destroy the mark silently rather than obviously.

3. The survey, measured

Eight faces were rendered and measured rather than eyeballed. Ink is the count of non-space glyph characters; ink density is ink as a percentage of the total cell area, which is a workable proxy for visual weight. All figures were produced by rendering each face and counting, not estimated.

Face	Rows	Cols	SON at	Cells	Ink	Density
banner	7	59	35	413	145	35.1%
big	8	50	30	400	161	40.2%
doom	8	47	28	376	156	41.5%
standard	6	47	29	282	134	47.5%
slant	6	49	30	294	151	51.4%
ogre	6	44	28	264	128	48.5%
larry3d — shipped	9	65	40	585	266	45.5%
mini	4	26	16	104	37	35.6%

Read the density column as weight. The three solid faces — `banner`, `doom` and `ogre` — carry the most ink per cell and read heaviest at small sizes. The outline faces carry less ink per cell but occupy more columns, because an outline must draw both edges of every stroke.

The measurement that mattered

The shipped face, **larry3d**, is the largest in every dimension: nine rows, sixty five columns, five hundred and eighty five cells and two hundred and sixty six ink characters. That is roughly twice the area of the smallest face surveyed. It was chosen anyway, which is a judgement: distinctiveness was weighted above compactness, and the cost is stated here so it is visible.

4. The drawings

Each face is drawn with the production treatment: the *Agent* half in brand amber, the *SON* half in bold amber, split at the measured column, over the shared tagline. The shipped face is marked. Faces are shown at the same point size, so relative width is honest.

banner

7 rows × 59 columns • split at column 35 • 145 ink characters

big

8 rows × 50 columns • split at column 30 • 161 ink characters

doom

8 rows × 47 columns • split at column 28 • 156 ink characters

standard

6 rows × 47 columns • split at column 29 • 134 ink characters

slant

6 rows × 49 columns • split at column 30 • 151 ink characters

ogre

6 rows × 44 columns • split at column 28 • 128 ink characters

larry3d — SHIPPED

9 rows × 65 columns • split at column 40 • 266 ink characters

mini

4 rows × 26 columns • split at column 16 • 37 ink characters

5. The split, and how it was verified

The mark renders *Agent* in brand amber and *SON* in bold amber. Both halves share the same rows, so the boundary cannot be found by searching the text. It is a fixed column, measured by rendering the word *Agent* alone and taking its widest row.

For the shipped face that column is **40**, and the mark is 65 columns wide, so the split leaves 25 columns to the right of it. The verification that matters is per row: every one of the nine rows must carry ink in both halves, or part of a glyph is being coloured as though it belonged to the other word.

Row	Agent ink ends	SON ink begins	Split	Verdict
1	column 40	column 40	40	clean edge
2	column 39	column 40	40	clean edge
3	column 40	column 40	40	clean edge
4	column 40	column 40	40	clean edge
5	column 39	column 40	40	clean edge
6	column 40	column 40	40	clean edge
7	column 40	column 40	40	clean edge
8	column 21	none	40	single-sided row
9	column 20	none	40	single-sided row

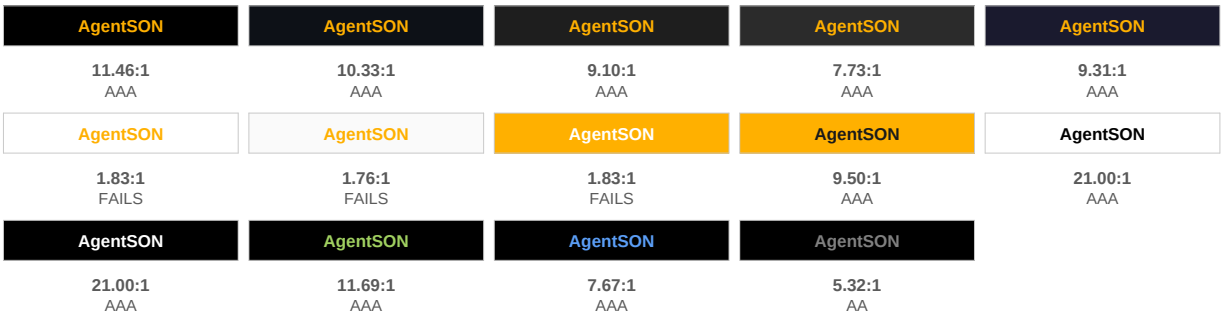
Rows eight and nine are the descender rows of the three-dimensional face — the trailing shadow strokes — and carry ink only on the left. They are correct as drawn; a short gap there is the face's own geometry, not a split error.

6. Colour, measured

Fourteen foreground and ground pairings were computed against the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines relative-luminance definition. The verdict thresholds are the standard ones: seven to one for AAA body text, four and a half for AA, three for large text and for non-text graphics such as block glyphs, and below three a failure.

Context	Foreground	Ground	Ratio	Verdict
Terminal default dark	#ffb000	#000000	11.46:1	AAA
GitHub dark	#ffb000	#0d1117	10.33:1	AAA
VS Code dark	#ffb000	#1e1e1e	9.10:1	AAA
Dim terminal	#ffb000	#2b2b2b	7.73:1	AAA
Terminal blue-black	#ffb000	#1a1a2e	9.31:1	AAA
Print / white paper	#ffb000	#ffffff	1.83:1	FAILS
Off-white paper	#ffb000	#fafafa	1.76:1	FAILS
Reversed: amber ground	#ffffff	#ffb000	1.83:1	FAILS
Reversed: dark on amber	#1a1a1a	#ffb000	9.50:1	AAA
Baseline black on white	#000000	#ffffff	21.00:1	AAA
Baseline white on black	#ffffff	#000000	21.00:1	AAA
Secondary green on dark	#a0d060	#000000	11.69:1	AAA
Secondary blue on dark	#5b9ef6	#000000	7.67:1	AAA
Muted grey on dark	#808080	#000000	5.32:1	AA

The swatches below are the same fourteen pairings drawn as ink, not described in words.



> **Forced decision: 3 pairings fail, and they share a ground**
>
> Every failure in the matrix is amber acting as ink on a light ground, or white on amber. Amber on white paper measures **1.83:1** — well under the three-to-one floor for non-text graphics, and legible on a terminal only because terminals put it on black. The same amber as a *ground* with dark ink measures **9.50:1**.

The consequence is a clean rule with two halves. **On screen the mark is amber on black**, because that is where the brand colour was tuned and it exceeds AAA everywhere tested. **On paper the mark is dark ink on white, or white ink on an amber ground**; amber is never used as ink. This handbook follows that rule throughout, which is why the printed mark you are reading is black and grey rather than amber.

The secondary palette was checked on the same terms. The green measures comfortably and the blue passes AAA on black, so both are safe as screen accents; neither is used in the mark.

7. The three-dimensional treatment

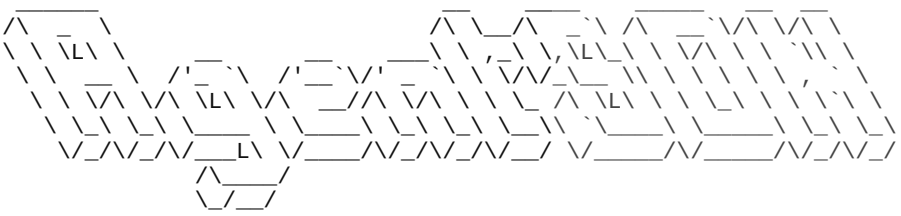
The shipped face is an outline face. Its three-dimensional read comes from drawing a second contour offset behind every stroke, not from shading a solid letter. That distinction matters, because an outline has no interior to shade and therefore no place to put a gradient, a highlight or a bevel.

A terminal offers exactly two levers: a different foreground, and a bold weight. There is no third. So on screen the entire dimensional effect is carried by the two-tone split — the lighter *Agent* half reading as the lit face and the bold *SON* half reading as the shadowed edge. That is the whole of the terminal treatment and it cannot be extended.

7.1 What a page can do that a terminal cannot

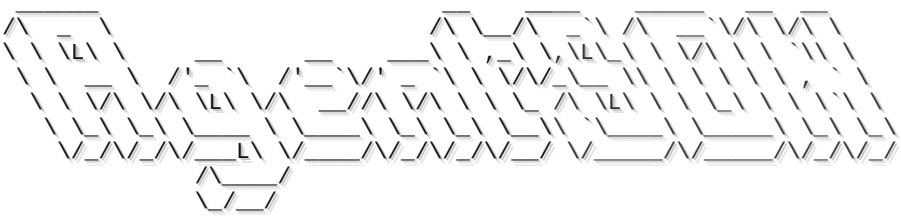
On paper the same face can be given a genuine drop shadow, because the drawing order is under explicit control. The three treatments below use identical glyph data; only the ink and the drawing order differ. Compare them at arm's length, which is where a drop shadow either earns its place or becomes noise.

Treatment A — flat, terminal parity



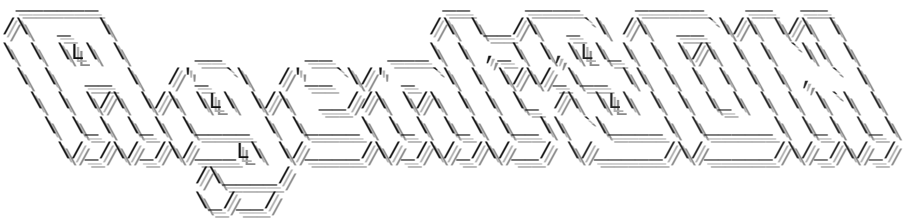
Two inks, no offsets. This is exactly what a terminal renders.

Treatment B — two-tone with a near shadow



One offset layer. Reads as depth at normal size without separating the strokes.

Treatment C — full drop shadow



Two offset layers. Strongest depth, and the first to collapse: below roughly eight points the layers merge into a smear.

Where the 3D effect does not render, and what to do instead

Three conditions defeat it, and each has a stated fallback rather than a hope. **Small type.** Below about eight points the offset is smaller than a pixel and the layers fuse; the fallback is treatment A, which loses nothing because the effect was already invisible. **A light ground with light ink.** The shadow needs to be darker than the face, so amber on white has no shadow ink available — a second reason that pairing is rejected in section six. **A terminal.** There is no canvas to offset against; the fallback is the two-tone split, which is what ships.

8. What broke, and why it is recorded

Four defects were introduced while building this mark. Three were found by rendering rather than by the test suite, which is the part worth taking away.

Defect	Symptom	Cause	Found by
Missing commas in the art tuple	Panel rendered blank with one stray hash	Adjacent string literals concatenate; enumerate() then walked 413 characters instead of 9 rows	Reading the render
Duplicate split constant	Five columns of the Agent half rendered bold	The installer replaced only to the tuple's closing paren, leaving the previous face's value behind; Python takes the last definition	Span count
Backslashes in plain string literals	SyntaxWarning, then an unterminated literal that broke the whole CLI	The outline face uses backslashes, one row ends in one, and a trailing backslash escapes the closing quote	Import
Colour measured with a non-existent escape	Reported zero colours on a correctly coloured render	A PowerShell escape valid only in version six was used in version five point one	Cross-check

> **The finding that outlasts all four**
>
> The test suite contains one hundred and ninety two tests and every one passed at every point above, including while `help_system.py` was a syntax error that would crash the command line on first use. No test imports the help system, so the suite cannot see it. A green suite is a statement about what was tested, and here it was a statement about schema validation and nothing else.

8.1 Encoding, and the one thing that never fixes itself

The console used throughout this work renders an em dash as a replacement character, because the code page cannot carry it. The file itself is strict UTF-8 with no byte order mark and contains real em dashes; only the display is wrong. Every file touched here was checked byte by byte after writing — strict decoding, byte order mark absent, em dash count positive — precisely because a visual check on this console is not evidence of anything.

9. The shipped mark

One constant block in `cli/help_system.py`, no runtime dependency, and a panel width that follows the art instead of the other way round.

Property	Value
Face	larry3d
Grid	9 rows by 65 columns
Split column	40
Glyph cells	585
Ink characters	266
Agent ink	`#ffb000`, ANSI 214
SON ink	`bold #ffb000`
Tagline	The universal provenance format for agent sessions.
Panel width	69 columns, capped at the console width
Print treatment	Dark ink on white, or white on amber; never amber on white

The font was generated once in an isolated environment and baked into the file as a string constant. Installing a lettering library as a dependency of a provenance tool, so that a heading can be drawn, would be the wrong trade.

Appendix A — every face, raw

banner

```
   #                                 #####  ####### #     #
  # #    ####  ###### #    # ##### #     # #     # ##    #
 #   #  #    # #      ##   #   #   #       #     # # #   #
#     # #      #####  # #  #   #    #####  #     # #  #  #
####### #  ### #      #  # #   #         # #     # #   # #
#     # #    # #      #   ##   #   #     # #     # #    ##
#     #  ####  ###### #    #   #    #####  ####### #     #
```

big

```
                      _    _____  ____  _   _
    /\                | |  / ____|/ __ \| \ | |
   /  \   __ _  ___ _ __ | |_| (___ | |  | |  \| |
  / /\ \ / _` |/ _ \ '_ \| __|\___ \| |  | | . ` |
 / ____ \ (_| |  __/ | | | |_ ____) | |__| | |\  |
/_/    \_\__, |\___|_| |_|\__|_____/ \____/|_| \_|
          __/ |
         |___/
```

doom

```
  ___                  _   _____  _____ _   _
 / _ \                | | /  ___||  _  | \ | |
/ /_\ \ __ _  ___ _ __ | |_\ `--. | | | |  \| |
|  _  |/ _` |/ _ \ '_ \| __|`--. \| | | | . ` |
| | | | (_| |  __/ | | | |_/\__/ /\ \_/ / |\  |
\_| |_/\__, |\___|_| |_|\__\____/  \___/\_| \_/
        __/ |
       |___/
```

standard

```
    _                    _   ____   ___  _   _
   / \   __ _  ___ _ __ | |_/ ___| / _ \| \ | |
  / _ \ / _` |/ _ \ '_ \| __\___ \| | | |  \| |
 / ___ \ (_| |  __/ | | | |_ ___) | |_| | |\  |
/_/   \_\__, |\___|_| |_|\__|____/ \___/|_| \_|
        |___/
```

slant

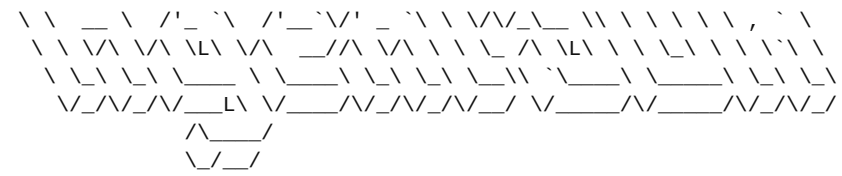
```
    ___                    __  _____ ____  _   __
   /   | ____ ____  ____  / /_/ ___// __ \/ | / /
  / /| |/ __ `/ _ \/ __ \/ __/\__ \/ / / /  |/ /
 / ___ / /_/ /  __/ / / / /_ ___/ / /_/ / /|  /
/_/  |_\__, /\___/_/ /_/\__//____/\____/_/ |_/
      /____/
```

ogre

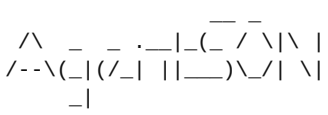
```
   _                    _   __    ___    __
  /_\   __ _  ___ _ __ | |_/ _\  /___\/\ \ \
 //_\\ / _` |/ _ \ '_ \| __\ \  //  //  \/ /
/  _  \ (_| |  __/ | | | |__\ \/ \_// /\  /
\_/ \_/\__, |\___|_| |_|\__\__/\___/\_\ \/
       |___/
```

larry3d

```
 ______                        __    ____    _____   __  __
/\  _  \                      /\ \__/\  _`\ /\  __`\/\ \/\ \
\ \ \L\ \     __      __    ___\ \ ,_\ \,\L\_\ \ \/\ \ \ `\\ \
```



mini



Appendix B — the shipped constant

Every row is emitted with its backslashes escaped by `repr()`, which is the fix for the defect recorded in section eight.

```
WORDMARK = (
    ' ______                    __   ____   _____  __  __      ',
    '/\\  _  \\                  /\\ \\/\\  _`\\ /\\  __`\\/\\ \\/\\ \\    ',
    '\\ \\ \\L\\ \\     __     __  \\ \\ ,_\\ \\,\\L\\_\\ \\ \\/\\ \\ \\ `\\\\ \\   ',
    " \\ \\  __ \\  /'_ `\\  /'__`\\ \\ \\/\\ \\/_\\__ \\\\ \\ \\ \\ \\ \\ , ` \\  ",
    '  \\ \\ \\/\\ \\/\\ \\L\\ \\/\\  __//\\ \\/\\ \\ \\ /\\ \\L\\ \\ \\ \\_\\ \\ \\ \\`\\ \\ ',
    '   \\ \\_\\ \\_\\ \\____ \\ \\____\\ \\_\\ \\_\\ \\__\\\\ `\\____\\ \\_____\\ \\_\\ \\_\\',
    '    \\/_/\\/_/\\/___L\\ \\/____/\\/_/\\/_/\\/__/ \\/_____/\\/_____/\\/_/\\/_/',
    '             /\\____/                                          ',
    '             \\_/__/                                           ',
)
WORDMARK_SON_START = 40
```